Who Am I – Writing Across Different Circumstances

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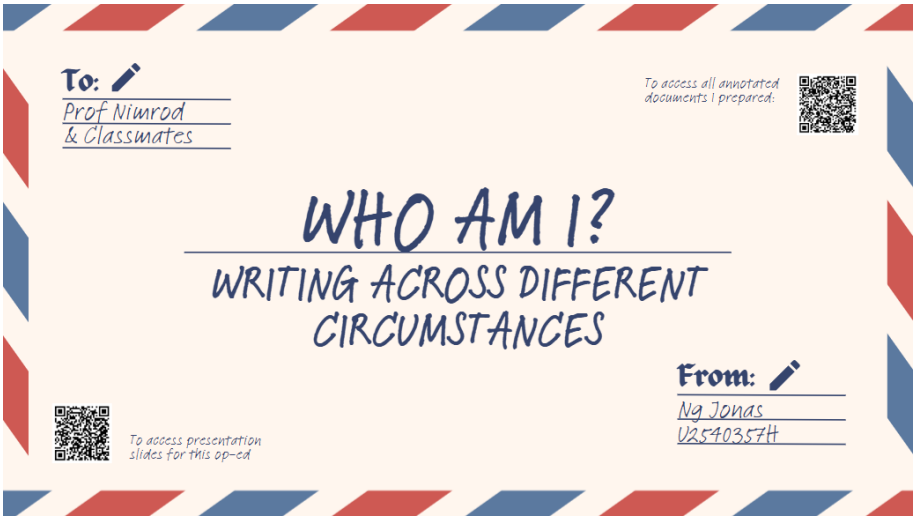


Figure 1. My presentation slide for this op-ed.

I have been staring blankly at my computer screen for the past three hours. For our 'Inquiry and Communication in an Interdisciplinary World' module, my professor has tasked us to write an op-ed. As a Biology student, writing has always been a daunting task - a nightmare - for me.

What is an op-ed anyway? And how do I - in his words - 'produce heat and light' *with it?*

The night sky twinkles mockingly as dawn threatens its arrival. I blink, not a thought behind my caffeinated, bloodshot eyes. We either choose a place in Singapore to explore, choose a community or subculture to discuss, or choose to analyse our own writing styles. *But what's there to analyse about my writing anyway?*

I pounce across my dorm room and pull out the notes I wrote carelessly in class earlier. Keywords, arrows and symbols sprawled haphazardly across the paper; curt, straightforward, with absolutely no regard for style, legibility, or structure whatsoever.

I cock an eyebrow; *no one's going to read this, anyway.*

Scrambling through crushed balls of paper in my bag, I come across the application essays I wrote months ago when I applied for universities:

Literary devices danced radiantly throughout my essays: literary tricolons, alliterations, and dramatic paragraphs flooded with adverbs. I also used cautionary disclaimers and quantifiers, disguised as nuance but in reality, weak attempts at answering questions that I was overly ambitious to tackle.

It was almost conniving - every word curated strategically to capture eyes and hearts; I was desperate to stand out from the other candidates. Frantic for achievements to paraphrase, "working with teachers" turned into "partnership with key

stakeholders", whilst "volunteering with elderly" somehow transformed into "significant societal movement for the vulnerable".

Such falsehood, I muse, *I should be eligible for a Nobel Peace Prize.*

I vividly remember the bewilderment on my parents' faces when they read my essays for the first time, "Wow, Jonas, did *you* write this? This doesn't sound like you!"

Their comment unfurled a whole ball of realisations inside me: *They are right; at times, my writing is drastically different from how I normally communicate.*

Without an audience, I am straightforward and practical. With competition, I am hypocritical and even dishonest. When writing about myself, I am self-aggrandising and self-righteous - dramatic, yet cautious.

Why? Why are there so many facades of myself?

This made me wonder if I was being my 'true-self' or simply presenting a curated facade as I write. As my pen dances across the paper, the conflict between myself as my 'true-self', and myself as simply a vehicle that different personalities and facades take turns occupying comes to the forefront of my mind.

Writing across different circumstances, how do these facades emerge? And how does this blur, conflate, and interact with the self?

This reminds me: my CC0001 professor discussed the importance of writing and close reading in our lessons. He emphasised the importance of penetrating through different disciplines, different lens while looking into a piece of literature. *Oh yes*, I realise, *he sent us some documents to read in preparation for our next lesson!*

Snapping back to reality, I scurry back to my computer and pulled out the two PDF files my professor had sent me: "Writing As Illusion" by Daryll Anderson (1984), and "Writing and the Unmaking of the Self" by Eugene Goodheart (1988).

Anderson's "Writing as Illusion" (1984) is an interesting, even *enthralling* read. "Absolutely honest self-expression is impossible in writing, for every sentence, every word, every temporal and logical arrangement compromise the whole, true self" (Anderson, 1984, p. 6): Anderson argues that writers create facades, intentionally curating words and ideas to present a certain outward appearance. On the other hand, honesty and truth in writing is "tiresome", "distracting", gives "no pleasure", and is "neither desirable nor possible" (Anderson, 1984, p. 7, 9, 11). In fact, he goes further by arguing that some falsehood is necessary for coherence, and may even be enjoyable for the readers – "people enjoy being deceived... the awareness to enjoy the spectacle" (Anderson, 1984, p. 8).

I squint my eyes - *Is Anderson saying that all writing is an illusion? Does he mean that there is no true self in writing?*

If there is no true self in writing, who am I? A repertoire of facades I have created in my writing? How do these facades interact with each other and with my identity as the writer?

To probe deeper, I open up the second PDF - "Writing and the Unmaking of the Self" by Eugene Goodheart (1988). Goodheart (1988) claims that as writers apply themselves to their passions, the self constantly 'unmakes' (fragments) and 'makes' (reshapes) itself through imagination and desire. Through imagination, the writer undergoes experiences without literally going through these experiences themself, such as death and an unlived alternate life. Desire, on the other

hand, is the destabilising force that tears apart the writer's coherence and control.

Just then. A sentence catches my eye.

"The natural being may be the skill itself, the innate capacity to impersonate… What I have instead is a variety of impersonations… a troupe of players… a permanent company of actors… an ever-evolving stock of pieces and parts that forms my repertoire" (Goodheart, 1988, p. 438).

I gasp - *Goodheart agrees with Anderson! In writing, there is no true self!*

I lean back in my chair, processing the overlap of both sources and their answers in response to my overall question.

Answering the first part of my overall question - "*Who are we? Are we being our true-selves or simply facades in our writing?*" - both authors agree that there is no true self in writing, and that facades evolve from the writer's construction of personas.

However, Goodheart (1988) goes further and describes the interactions between the self and the facades (and even between the facades), answering the second part of my overall question - "*How do these facades blur, conflate, and interact with the self?*" Writing destroys and fragments, makes and unmakes the self, where multiple fragments of the self coexist, collide, and even erase each other within the act of writing.

I wince, *but there* are *some differences between Anderson's (1984) and Goodheart's (1988) claims*: Anderson (1984) feels that the creation of these facades is deliberate, where the writer has high control, whereas Goodheart (1988) believes that these facades evolve from the inevitable dissolution of the self, where the writer has limited control. Anderson (1984) believes that there is a pre-existing writer's self that is lived through the created persona, but Goodheart (1988) contends that the writer's self is plural, performative and always in flux, never a single entity in the first place.

Reflecting inwards, Anderson's (1984) arguments and Goodheart's (1988) assertions also have differing applications in my own life, too. Compared to Goodheart's (1988) foreign assertions, Anderson's (1984) claims apply more closely to myself: I intentionally curated and arranged my ideas to form a desired outward appearance to the university interviewers, where I used some falsehood - perhaps an *enjoyable and amusing* falsehood - to gently deceive the interviewers.

If I were to provide my own insights, what if, the self does not exist before writing and is *created through* writing? Opposing what both authors believe, perhaps the self is formed part by part, facade by facade, through writing - where writing is self-creation, not fragmentation. For example, writing differently for different purposes reflects how I behave differently when portraying myself to others versus to myself, but both are different sides of the same coin (my 'true self').

Furthermore, although both Anderson (1984) and Goodheart (1988) excuse some levels of falsehood (which I concede is somewhat inevitable in writing), we must stay true to the core values of honesty, integrity and respect. As ethical writers, we must never write with the intent to misinform others; and just like all other forms of communication, writing should be done for the growth of individuals and humanity.

I nod profoundly; *this will be my* 'heat and light'. Challenging Anderson's (1984) view of truth as *boring* and *undesirable*, I should work towards greater genuineness as a writer, creating personas that reduce falsehood and resemble my true self as much as possible.

I sigh. As a Biology student, this topic is certainly more than *'a daunting nightmare'* to unpack. However, in the spirit of 'inquiry into different disciplines', I should give it a try.

The morning's threat finally dawns on me, as my bloodshot eyes fade into a darkened shade of enlightenment.

I think... I know what I am going to write for my op-ed.

Acknowledgements

I have always believed that any artistic work – be it an essay, a painting, a piece of music – is not created by a single person alone. Yes, the completed work could truly have been done by one person, but the person's thoughts, artistic style, and so on is likely to be a curation of their community of people. For myself, I owe my writing style to many people: first and foremost, my family, who serves as my basis in life, to strive for excellence in what I do. Secondly, my CC0001 tutor Prof Nimrod, whose guidance, advice, and encouragement were genuinely the reasons why I managed to persevere through this challenging topic. Last but certainly not least, my best friend and brother, Cai Xin Ze, who significantly helped me grow into the man I am today, my values and my perspective in life. Thank you for being my best friend and brother, Xin Ze. Do check out his op-ed: 'The Solo and the Self: Finding a Voice in Jazz'. Writing is communication, to express our opinions, to hold ourselves upright, and to showcase our personality. Go out there, start writing.

References

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